

Prickly Feat

The glasshouse in Bangalore's Lalbagh Botanical Garden bristles with over 300 species of cacti as it prepares to open its doors to the public



PARKSHIT RAO

**A TREAT FOR
CACTUS LOVERS**

| By Stephen David |

Where can you find the 'Old Man of the Andes' and 'Arizona Queen of the Night' next to each other? Or 'Bishop's Cap' and 'Cat and Kittens' under the same roof as a 'Joshua Tree' or an 'Organ Pipe'? In a cactus house, of course. Old Man of the Andes is the common name of *Oreocereus celsianus*, and Arizona Queen of the Night is *Peniocereus greggi*, both cactus species. And Joshua Tree—one of the greatest albums in rock history from Irish rock band U2—in cacti lingo is *Yucca brevifolia*.

Bangalore will soon throw its doors open to these exotic ornamental and medicinal plants at the 250-acre Lalbagh Botanical Garden, founded by warrior Tipu Sultan's father Hyder Ali in the 18th century. But the honour of showcasing the country's largest outdoor cacti collection goes to Chandigarh. About 300 varieties will be on show at the Rs 25-lakh, 6,000-sq-ft cactus house. "This is the largest indoor collection of cacti in India and we hope to go beyond 1,000 varieties by next year," says Lalbagh horticulturist M. Jagadeesh, also deputy director at the Karnataka Horticulture Department. Officials of

the department have been working on the idea for four years, sourcing plants from across the country.

Common cacti names, always creatively given, will make the show more interesting. The size of 'Organ Pipes' and 'Bishop's Caps' varies between one foot and two-storeys. Some are the size of a football while others look like large bean bags. Elephant watchers can take satisfaction seeing the 'Elephant's Tooth' (*Mammillaria elephantidens*). For those with medieval inclinations, there are enough 'White Knights'. Horticulture Department Director N. Jayaram wants more than 2,000 species to match the 300-acre, 250-year-old Kew Gardens near London that houses the world's largest collection of living plants and attracts nearly two million visitors every year.

Garden enthusiasts like Sarasa Vasudevan, a social entrepreneur, point out: "When you are battling water scarcity, it is a great idea to landscape the outdoors with cacti." Prickly the plants can be, but it is a giant leap for a botanical garden that nurtures ambitions to grow to the stature of the magnificent Kew in UK. ■